

How Indium Tin Oxide Powers Modern Touchscreens and Displays

Philip C. Wang

ENMA301

Professor Isabel Lloyd

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Introduction

Every time a person swipes a smartphone screen or taps their laptop display, they are interacting with transparent conductive films (TCFs), which are thin coatings that must have both low electrical resistance, so that signals or electric fields can be transmitted across the electrode with minimal loss, and high optical transmittance, so that the underlying display remains visually clear to the user. One of the most commonly used TCFs is indium tin oxide (ITO), a wide bandgap semiconductor that has tin doping, causing a high density of free charge carriers and enabling electrical resistivities while still allowing for high visible light transmittance. This paper examines ITO as the dominant TCF in modern technology, exploring the fundamental materials science that makes this unique combination of properties possible, the manufacturing techniques used to produce it, and the current performance limitations and sustainability issues that are also driving research forward into potential alternative materials.

Material Overview

ITO is composed primarily of indium (III) oxide (In_2O_3) doped with approximately 10% tin (IV) oxide (SnO_2). The material exhibits a cubic bixbyite crystal structure (Fig. 1), where tin atoms substitute for indium atoms. Each substitution introduces a free electron that generates a high carrier concentration ($\sim 10^{20}$ - 10^{21} cm^{-3}) responsible for ITO's metallic-like conductivity (Stadler, 2012). Simultaneously, the wide bandgap of In_2O_3 (~ 3.5 - 4.3 eV) ensures that photons in the visible light spectrum lack the required energy to excite electrons across the gap, so visible light can pass through freely. Typical resistivity values are around $10^{-4} \Omega \cdot \text{cm}$, with optical transmittance above 85% in the visible range. The combination of wide bandgap ($\sim 3.7 \text{ eV}$) and n-type conductivity originates from oxygen vacancies and donor states provided by tin substitution, making ITO a very ideal material for transparent electrode applications.

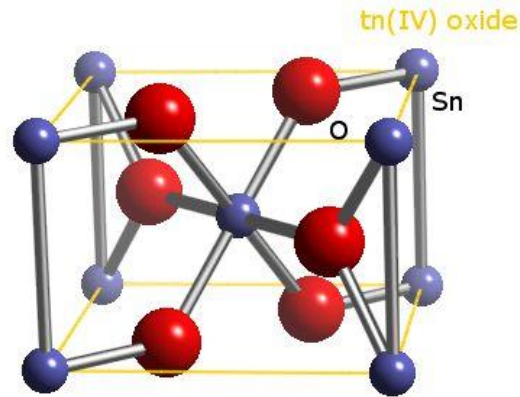


Figure 1: Bixbyite crystal structure of In_2O_3 . Tin dopant atoms (Sn^{4+}) substitute into indium sites (In^{3+}), contributing one free electron per substitution and generating the high carrier concentration responsible for ITO's electrical conductivity.

Material Properties

The performance of a transparent conductive film is evaluated using the two primary metrics that were mentioned above: sheet resistance and optical transmittance across the visible spectrum. For touchscreen and display applications, both must be simultaneously optimized. Resistance should be as low as possible to minimize signal loss across the electrode, while transmittance should be as high as possible to avoid perceptible optical degradation in the display image (Minami, 2005). These two properties are generally opposing, because increasing film thickness generally lowers sheet resistance by providing more conducting material, but also reduces the optical transmittance. Conversely, making the film thinner increases its transmittance but raises electrical resistance. However, ITO's exceptional ability to achieve an exceptionally low resistivity ($\sim 1\text{--}5 \times 10^{-4} \Omega \cdot \text{cm}$) and very high transmittance ($>85\%$) simultaneously is what places it in a distinct performance class that other materials have not yet been able to reliably match and succeed in.

Carrier mobility in ITO is heavily shaped by several scattering mechanisms, including grain boundary scattering, ionized impurity scattering from excess tin dopants, and neutral impurity scattering.

In amorphous ITO films, which are typically deposited at room temperature, grain boundary scattering is absent, but overall carrier mobility is lower due to greater structural disorder. In crystallized, annealed films, carrier mobilities can reach 30–80 $\text{cm}^2/\text{V}\cdot\text{s}$, which is considerably high for an oxide semiconductor (Stadler, 2012). The final electrical resistivity of a film is determined by both the carrier concentration and mobility, and both are strongly influenced by processing conditions. This tight coupling between ITO's microstructure, whether grain size, crystallinity, or defect density, is one of the key metrics that allows ITO to perform the way it does, and it is why deposition conditions must be carefully controlled.

Manufacturing and Deposition Methods

Today, the most commercially widespread method for depositing ITO films is magnetron sputtering (Fig. 2), where ITO is sputtered with energetic argon ions in a vacuum chamber, ejecting material that then condenses as a thin film on a substrate (Patel et al., 2024). There are two main types of magnetron sputtering: direct current (DC) and radio frequency (RF) magnetron sputtering, both of which are used in industrial workplaces. DC sputtering uses a constant negative voltage to accelerate ions into the target, offers faster deposition rates, and is preferred for large-scale production since it is generally simpler and cheaper. In contrast, RF sputtering uses a radio power supply (typically at 13.56 MHz) to alternate the polarity of the target, is a better choice for insulators, and also provides finer control at the expense of lower deposition rates and higher costs. The choice between the two for depositing ITO ultimately depends on the manufacturer and the different tradeoffs for varying material applications.

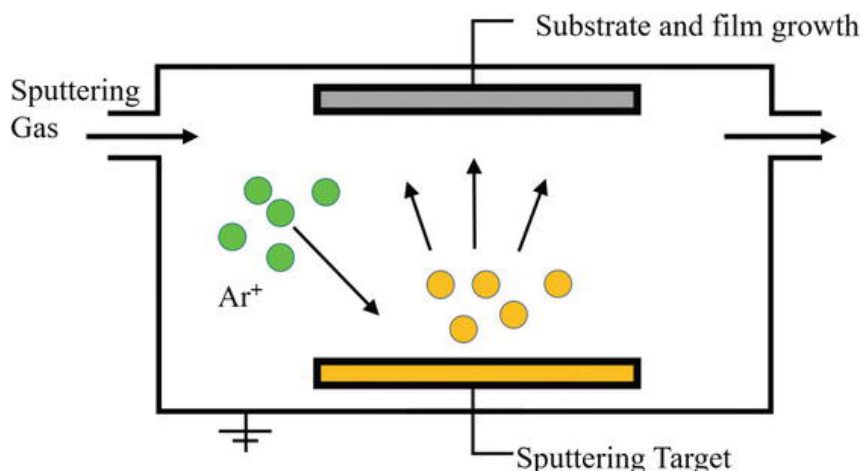


Figure 2: Schematic of a DC magnetron sputtering system. Argon gas is ionized to form a plasma, and the resulting Ar^+ ions are accelerated toward the target, ejecting the target material, which then condenses as a thin film on the substrate.

Thus, the structural and electrical properties of ITO films are highly sensitive to deposition parameters. Substrate temperature is one of the most critical variables. Films deposited at room temperature are generally amorphous, while those deposited at temperatures above roughly 150–200°C or annealed develop a polycrystalline microstructure (Granqvist & Hultåker, 2002). Polycrystalline films typically exhibit lower resistivity due to improved atomic order and reduced structure defects, making post-deposition annealing a standard step in ITO film processing. Oxygen partial pressure during sputtering is another key variable, since too little oxygen creates oxygen vacancies that act as additional donors and can increase carrier concentration, while a surplus of oxygen can compensate the tin donors and reduce conductivity. Film thickness also matters because while thicker films have lower sheet resistance, there is a practical minimum thickness (~100–200 nm) below which films become discontinuous and lose their conducting properties (Minami, 2005). Together, these interdependencies between microstructure, processing variables, performance, and properties weave together to serve as a visual representation of the materials science tetrahedron.

Beyond sputtering, other deposition techniques including pulsed laser deposition (PLD) and chemical vapor deposition (CVD) have been investigated for specific applications. PLD can also produce high-quality crystalline ITO films at low substrate temperatures and has been used in research settings but has not yet been widely adopted for actual industrial production due to its low throughput and current manufacturing limitations (Stadler, 2012). Magnetron sputtering still remains the primary method due to its scalability and its well-understood process control, though ongoing research into low-temperature deposition on flexible polymer substrates is continuing to push the boundaries of ITO manufacturing.

Applications in Touchscreens and Displays

ITO's role in touchscreen devices is to function as a TCF that can detect the capacitive changes caused by a human's touch, or a projected capacitive touchscreen (PCT). As seen in Figure 3 below, in a PCT, a grid of ITO electrode lines is patterned on a glass or polymer substrate. When a finger approaches the surface, it interacts with the electric field between intersecting electrode lines, and that change in capacitance is detected and localized by the device's controller (Patel et al., 2024). For applications like such, ITO's great combination of low sheet resistance, high optical clarity, and compatibility with photolithographic patterning makes it essentially irreplaceable with current manufacturing infrastructure.

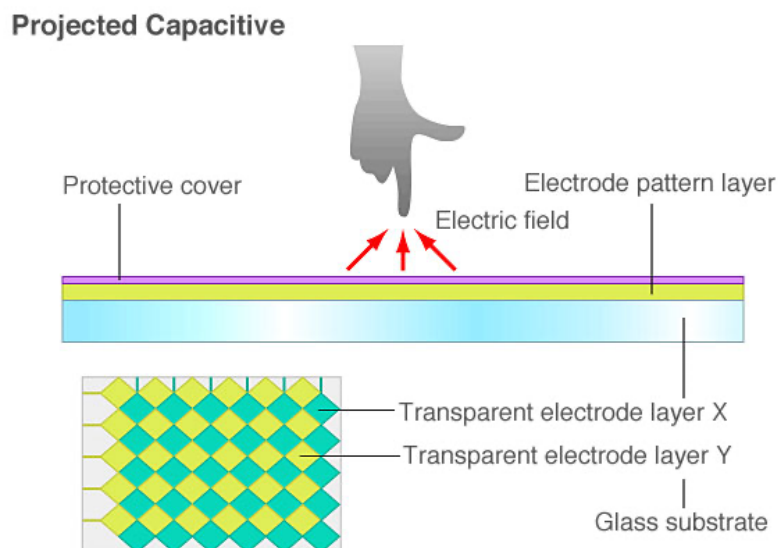


Figure 3: Schematic of a projected capacitive touchscreen showing a grid of transparent conductive electrodes. As a conductive finger is brought close to an intersection, it “steals” some of the electrical charge, which can then be accurately triangulated by the screen’s controller.

In liquid crystal displays (LCDs), ITO serves as the transparent electrode that applies the electric field required to align liquid crystal molecules and control pixel brightness (Samsung Display Newsroom, 2024). The ITO layer is deposited directly on the glass substrates that sandwich the liquid crystal layer. Because it must be patterned at the pixel level, the ability to etch ITO into fine features using standard photochemical processes is a major practical advantage. In organic light-emitting diode (OLED) displays, ITO is used as the anode material through which holes are injected into the organic emitting layers. Its high work function ($\sim 4.5\text{--}5.0$ eV) is well-matched to the ionization potentials of common hole-transport materials, making it an excellent anode without needing any modification (Ellmer, 2012).

It is important to reflect on what alternatives to ITO have also been considered. Table 1 below compares ITO to the most commonly researched alternative TCFs. While aluminum-doped zinc oxide (AZO) and gallium-doped zinc oxide (GZO) can approach ITO's electrical performance in laboratory

settings, ITO consistently has a lower resistivity and higher transmittance under manufacturing conditions. More importantly, there is existing knowledge of ITO due to decades of optimized deposition processes, etching chemistry, and integration with existing display manufacturing lines, gives it a much bigger practical advantage over the other alternatives that are less effective as of right now (Ellmer, 2012; Patel et al. (2024); Stadler, 2012).

Material	Resistivity ($\Omega\cdot\text{cm}$)	Transmittance (%)	Band Gap (eV)	Contains Indium?
ITO ($\text{In}_2\text{O}_3\text{:Sn}$)	$\sim 1 \times 10^{-4}$	>85	3.5–4.3	Yes
AZO (ZnO:Al)	$\sim 2 \times 10^{-4}$	>80	3.3–3.7	No
FTO ($\text{SnO}_2\text{:F}$)	$\sim 5 \times 10^{-4}$	>75	3.6–4.0	No
GZO (ZnO:Ga)	$\sim 1 \times 10^{-4}$	>80	3.3–3.7	No

Table 1: Comparison of key properties of common transparent conductive oxide materials, including aluminum-doped zinc oxide, fluorine-doped tin oxide, and gallium-doped zinc oxide. It should be emphasized how ITO has the greatest transmittance out of the alternative materials due to its higher-ranged bandgap, and its resistivity is among the lowest.

Current Limitations and Environmental Impact

Despite its dominance in the TCF market, ITO faces significant performance and supply constraints. Mechanically speaking, ITO is brittle. As a ceramic, it fractures at tensile strains of roughly 1–2%, well below the deformation tolerances that flexible or foldable display formats require (Patel et al., 2024). This is not necessarily a processing defect but rather a consequence of its ionic bonding character, which greatly limits the possibility of using it as for new and emerging flexible electronics applications. On the supply side, indium is a rare metal that is primarily sourced as a byproduct of zinc mining. The

scarcity and rising demand for touchscreen devices make indium prices highly volatile, with fluctuations of up to 30% annually (Ellmer, 2012). Production is also heavily concentrated in a small number of countries, and there is no commercially viable drop-in substitute, leading indium to even be classified as a critical material by major economies.

The sustainability picture is similarly challenging across ITO's full lifecycle. Upstream, indium refining involves high-temperature smelting, acid leaching, and solvent extraction, all of which are energy-intensive steps that cause landscape disruption and acid mine drainage. The magnetron sputtering process itself is also inefficient, as only 20–30% of the ITO target material is actually deposited onto the substrate, since the rest is wasted on chamber walls (Granqvist & Hultåker, 2002). The most pressing concern, however, is end-of-life.

The vast majority of ITO-containing devices are discarded as e-waste and attempting to recover that indium is both technically challenging and rarely practiced at commercial scale (Patel et al., 2024). Indium is present only in trace quantities in each device, and the cost of recovering it from disassembled waste streams has historically not been viable compared to its production. The overall result is that most of the indium embedded in discarded displays is now permanently lost to landfill or low-value smelting operations rather than being returned back to the supply chain, demonstrating a critical resource efficiency failure given indium's designation as a supply-constrained material. Fortunately, improving ITO recycling infrastructure or transitioning to alternative TCF materials that do not depend on scarce metals are both paths that researchers and policymakers are actively pursuing (Ellmer, 2012).

Conclusion

ITO holds a rare yet significant position in modern materials science. Due to its combination of electrical conductivity, optical transparency, and compatibility with photolithographic processing, ITO is

so well-suited to transparent electrode applications that decades of industry investment have become locked around it, despite limitations having grown more apparent in recent years. Its wide bandgap and tin-donor conductivity explain why it performs so well, and the process of magnetron sputtering explains why it can be manufactured reliably at scale. Yet at the same time, ITO's ceramic brittleness imposes real constraints on flexible electronics, and its dependence on geographically concentrated and rare indium supply chain introduces risk that will only intensify as demand grows across displays, touchscreens, and photovoltaics simultaneously. Sustainability considerations revolve around these concerns, as indium mining, energy-intensive sputtering with low target utilization, and the near-total absence of ITO recycling at end of life mean that the material's lifecycle footprint is considerably larger than its thin-film presence in any individual device might suggest.

The transparent conductor field continues to remain one of the most active areas of materials research. Whether any prospective TCF alternatives can match ITO's combination of performance, processability, and manufacturing remains an open question, but it is important to acknowledge that economic and environmental pressures to find a viable substitute are real and continuing to grow.

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